

International Economic Development

ECON 4660-8666, Fall 2026

Professor: Dr. Zhigang Feng

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Classroom: Mammel Hall 324, M, 18:00-20:40

Office Hours: M&W, 9:30-10:30

or by appointment

Zoom link: <https://unomaha.zoom.us/j/4025542786?pwd=OGVwTCtjaTJQWGg5b1NjMHBPdkV0QT09>

Course Description and Learning Objectives

This course provides an immersive exploration into the theories of economic development and growth, as well as their practical applications. The primary focus of the curriculum is to illuminate the economic challenges that confront developing nations, presenting students with a comprehensive understanding of the diverse factors influencing these economies.

A range of domestic economic matters are scrutinized, including the level and growth rate of per capita GDP - pivotal indicators of a nation's economic health. The course delves into the critical aspects of income distribution, a fundamental determinant of societal wealth disparity. The correlation between population trends and economic outcomes is examined, along with the ubiquitous issue of unemployment. We further investigate the implications of urbanization on economic development, bearing in mind the ongoing global trend towards urban living. A profound emphasis is placed on education, recognizing its paramount role in fostering economic advancement. The course also presents an analysis of fiscal and financial policies, aiming to equip students with the tools to evaluate their impacts on economic stability and growth.

Beyond domestic concerns, the curriculum extends to international economic issues. It delves into the complexities of global trade, acknowledging its integral part in shaping developing economies. The role of foreign investments in

bolstering economic growth is examined, along with the double-edged sword of foreign debt and its potential to either stimulate or stagnate economies.

Prerequisites:

It is assumed that the student has taken Econ 2200 (principles of microeconomics) and Econ 2220 (principles of macroeconomics).

Course Requirements:

There is one exam and a course paper (substitute for final exam). Graduate and undergraduate students will be given different exams. An outline of the paper should be submitted to the instructor before Nov. 5 and the final version of the paper should be submitted to the instructor by Dec 15. Homework will be assigned regularly.

Required assignments:

HomeWorks: Sep 21 – Nov 23, 21%

Midterm: Monday, Oct 12 (tentative), 18%

Student-led discussion: Nov 9 – Nov 16, 18%

Term paper presentation: Nov 23 – Dec 7, 8%

Attendance: Nov 9 – Dec 7, 18%

Final: research paper, due Dec. 16, 17%.

Grading Scale:

Grade	Threshold	Grade	Threshold
A+	97-100%	C	73-76.9%
A	93-96.9%	C-	70-72.9%
A-	90-92.9%	D+	67-69.9%
B+	87-89.9%	D	63-66.9%
B	83-86.9%	D-	60-62.9%
B-	80-82.9%	F	59.9% or less
C+	77-79.9%		

Textbook

Required Textbook: *Economics of Development 7th edition* by Dwight H. Perkins, Steven Radelet, David L. Lindauer, Steven A. Block, W.W. Norton & Company, Inc., 2012.

REFERENCE BOOKS:

- “Deaths of Despair and the Future of Capitalism”, by Anne Case, Angus Deaton

- “Poor Economics: A Radical Rethinking of the Way to Fight Global Poverty.” by Abhijit V. Banerjee.

Course Website

Course information is available on <https://mynu.instructure.com>.

Tentative Agenda (subject to changes)

<i>Week of</i>	<i>Monday</i>	<i>Due</i>
Aug. 24	Chp 1, 2: Introduction, Patterns of development	
Aug. 31	Chp 3: Empirical Evidence on Economic Growth	
Sep. 7	Labor day	
Sep. 14	Chp 4: Growth theory	
Sep. 21	Chp 6: Inequality and poverty	Homework 1
Sep. 28	Chp 7: Population	
Oct. 5	Chp 8: Education, Chp 9: Health	
Oct. 12	Midterm exam	
Oct. 19	Semester break	
Oct. 26	Migration and Economics Development	Homework 2
Nov. 2	Chp 10: Saving and investment, Chp 11. 12: Fiscal and Financial Policies	
Nov. 9	Student-led discussion, randomly chosen team, attendance required	
Nov. 16	Student-led discussion, randomly chosen team, attendance required	
Nov. 23	Final project presentation , randomly chosen students, attendance required	Homework 3
Nov. 30	Final project presentation , randomly chosen students, attendance required	
Dec. 7	Final project presentation , randomly chosen students, attendance required	
Dec. 15	No class	Final paper

Course Outline and Reading Assignment:

- I. Introduction:** Why study development economics? Patterns of development
- A. Stages of Economic Development
- B. Characteristics of the Developing Countries

Perkins, Chapter 1, Chapter 2

II. Economic Growth and Structural Change: How do you measure growth and development? What are some of the common indicators? What makes countries grow? What are some of the characteristics of high growth economies?

A. Empirical Evidence on Economic Growth

Perkins, Chapter 3

B. Exogenous Growth Model

Perkins, Chapter 4

C. Endogenous Growth Model

III. Income Distribution and Poverty: What do we mean by inequality? How is inequality related to poverty and development?

A. Concepts and measures

B. Theories and patterns of inequality and poverty

Perkins, Chapter 6

IV. Human Resources: What is the relationship between population growth and poverty? What are the causes of rapid population growth, the effects of such growth, and policy options? What is the relationship between education and development? What is the reality of health conditions in developing countries? What are some of the challenges to improving health conditions in developing countries?

A. Population

Perkins, Chapter 7

B. Education

Perkins, Chapter 8

C. Health

Perkins, Chapter 9

V. Savings, Investment, and Government Policies: How do different sources of savings and investment affect growth and development? What is the role of Foreign Direct Investment?

A. Saving and Investment

Perkins, Chapter 10

B. Government Fiscal Policies

Perkins, Chapter 11

C. Government Financial Policies

Perkins, Chapter 12

D. Foreign Investment and Debt

Perkins, Chapter 13 and 14

Journals Specialized in Economic Development:

Economic Development and Cultural Changes

Journal of Development Economics

Review of Economic Development

The World Development

The World Economy

Some Data Sources:

International Financial Statistics, the International Monetary Fund

Government Finance Statistics Yearbook, the International Monetary Fund

World Economic Outlook, the International Monetary Fund

World Development Report, the World Bank

Human Development Report, the United Nations

Penn. World Table, University of Pennsylvania

Additional policies:

Course attendance policy:

Attendance is expected. Course assessment is entirely based upon material covered in lecture.

UNO's requirements for Academic Integrity and Behavior:

All students are required to adhere to the highest standards of academic integrity and behavior and must satisfy the **UNO Academic Integrity Policy**

<http://www.unomaha.edu/student-life/student-conduct-and-community-standards/policies/academic-integrity.php> and

Student Code of Conduct

<http://www.unomaha.edu/student-life/student-conduct-and-community-standards/policies/code-of-conduct.php> .

It is the student's responsibility to read, understand and abide by these policies.

Campus emergency clause:

In the event of a major campus emergency, course requirements, deadlines and grading percentages are subject to changes that may be necessitated by a revised semester calendar or other circumstances beyond the instructor's control.

Students with disabilities:

Any student who feels s/he may need an accommodation based on the impact of a disability should contact me privately to discuss your specific needs. I will then get in touch with the Disability Resource Center to coordinate reasonable accommodations.

If you are unsure whether you need counseling or want help on a non-urgent matter that is affecting your overall wellbeing, consider a UNO Health & Wellness Coach.

Wellness Coaches work with students on matters including:

• Stress reduction • Study planning • Time management • Academic success strategies • Goal setting • Motivation • Gallup Strengths-based coaching • Sleep strategies

If a referral to Counseling is appropriate, a wellness coach will ease the process.

To schedule an appointment, call 402.554.3523 or unostudentaffairs@unomaha.edu

Description of the Paper

Writing Center webpage - <https://www.unomaha.edu/college-of-arts-and-sciences/writing-center/index.php>

Math and Science Learning Center: <https://www.unomaha.edu/college-of-arts-and-sciences/math-science-learning-center/index.php>

A. Topic:

Pick one developing country and discuss how that country has confronted a specific problem of economic development. For example, you may write about poverty in Ghana, population growth in China, agriculture in Colombia, etc.

Before Oct 30, you must hand to me a one paragraph description of the country and topic you plan to study, as well as a short bibliography (including at least three articles and/or books).

B. Structure:

The structure of the paper should be as follows.

- i. Briefly describe the economy and history of the country you are studying (2-3 pages).
- ii. Describe the problem or issue that you will discuss and how it relates to the country you are studying (2-3 pages).
- iii. Discuss the policies the government has enacted, or plans to enact, to address the issue or problem (4-5 pages).

iv. Lastly, analyze these policies from the point of view of a development economist and present your own opinion and analysis of the policies used by the government (2-3 pages). Your opinion and analysis should be based on your knowledge of economics.

C. Possible Sources:

You may consult books, newspapers, magazines, or scholarly journal articles. I strongly encourage you to cite scholarly journal articles. Some scholarly journals which may help are: World Development, Latin American Research Review, Journal of Developing Areas, Journal of Development Studies, Economic Development and Cultural Change, and Journal of Development Economics. Another good source of articles is the World Bank Working Paper series, which are available on line. Possible sources of data include the World Development Report of the World Bank, the UN Statistical Tables, the UN Human Development Report, and the IMF World Financial Outlook.

D. Citing Sources:

You must cite the sources for the information used in your paper. It is necessary to always cite sources not only for direct quotes but also when you are paraphrasing data or arguments that are not your own. The paper must also include a bibliography. The bibliography should contain only those articles and books that you consulted (read) in writing the paper.

“Plagiarism” is when you represent the words and/or ideas of others as your own. If you do not cite the sources of the words and ideas of others that you use in your paper, you are guilty of plagiarism. Plagiarism is a violation of the UNO honor code, and if you plagiarize you can be expelled from the university. Because there are very good computer programs available to help professors to detect plagiarism, plagiarism is also relatively easy to detect. If I find that you have plagiarized in your papers, you will be punished in accordance with the UNO honor code, so don’t do it.

You may use any generally accepted method of citing sources in your paper. I suggest citing sources by including after the information: (Authors, date of publication), with the full citation in the bibliography. Below are two examples, the first citing the source of a direct quote, the second citing the source of an argument which I paraphrase.

Example One: According to one authority, “bad writing does not get read” (McCloskey, 1987).

Example Two: Many economists write very badly (McCloskey, 1987).

You may use any generally accepted method in your bibliography. I suggest that your bibliography refer to books and article in the following manners:

For books:

Author(s), date published, Title of Book, publisher, city of publication.

Mitch, David, 1992, *The Rise of Popular Literacy in Victorian England: the Influence of Private Choice and Public Policy*, University of Pennsylvania Press, Philadelphia.

For journal articles:

Author(s), date published, "Title of Article," Journal, Volume, Number, month of publication, page numbers.

Gindling, T. H., Marsha Goldfarb and Chun-Chig Chang, 1995, "Changing Returns to Education in Taiwan," *World Development*, Vol. 23, No. 2, February, pp. 343-356.

For the internet:

Author (or organization), date published, "title of article or web page," web address (you must provide me with enough information that I can find the information for myself).

Inter-American Development Bank, 2001 (January 1), "Power Sharing," www.iadb.org/idbamerica/Englist/JAN01E/jan01e7.html.

(Note: if you cannot identify the author or organization that provided the information on the internet, then DO NOT USE that information in your report.)

E. Spelling and Grammar:

Points will be subtracted from your grade for bad spelling and grammar. I suggest that you write your paper using a word processor and use the "spell-checker."

F. Length of the Paper:

The paper must be between 10 and 15 double-spaced pages. The margins (top, bottom, left and right) cannot be more than one inch. The font used must be 12 point or smaller.

G. Grading:

If your paper fulfills all of the above requirements, you will receive a minimum grade of approximately 75%. Your grade will be higher if you cite and use articles from professional journals, and if your paper is well-written and well-reasoned.

Points will be subtracted from your grade if you do not fulfill the above requirements, for example:

- If you do not include a bibliography, 10 points will be subtracted from your grade; if you do not cite the sources of the information you use, up to 25 points will be subtracted from your grade.
- If your paper is too short, between 10 and 25 points will be subtracted from your grade. Your paper is too short if you have fewer than 10 pages, use a larger font than required, or have margins that are larger than required.

- If you do not include all of the sections described in B, points will be subtracted from your grade. For example, if you do not include a brief description of the economy and history of the country you are studying, 5 points will be subtracted from your grade. If you do not include your own opinion and analysis of the policies used by the government, 10 points will be subtracted from your grade.

H. Presentation: You are required to give a *30 minutes* in class presentation of your paper. Your presentation will be graded based on the following aspect

Math and Science Learning Center: <https://www.unomaha.edu/college-of-arts-and-sciences/math-science-learning-center/index.php>

- Delivery
 - i. Appropriate volume and rate
 - ii. Speech is varied to show emphasis and interest
 - iii. Appropriate posture, eye contact, facial expressions and gestures
 - iv. Language choice directly and clearly presents topic
- Content
 - i. Clear and consistent focus with appropriate transitions between main ideas
 - ii. Speaker demonstrates substantial knowledge of subject
 - iii. Main ideas are clearly supported through research
 - iv. Speaker effectively communicates content to audience
- Organization
 - i. Organized with appropriate beginning, body, and conclusion
 - ii. Speech organization is clear and logically sequenced
 - iii. Exhibits research by use of various supporting materials
 - iv. Message is clearly presented
- Evidence of Student Learning
 - i. Able to respond intelligently and accurately to questioning
 - ii. Demonstrates thorough understanding of topic
 - iii. Clearly explains process used to develop product
 - iv. Able to reflect on process and communicate learning experience

All student must be ready before Nov 22 and the presenting student will be randomly chosen on the day of class.

Group Presentation

A. Group:

Each student will join one of the three groups (randomly) at the first day of class.

<https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/13EImJdYs1PyQ2W7B6e70zaGg4YXhN4XgwjUjytGXpgY/edit?usp=sharing>

B. Topic:

Each group pick one or two books from the list of reference books.

C. Presentation:

Each group have entire in-class session to discuss the books chosen. See the google doc for details on the suggested presentation questions.

All group must be ready before Nov 1 and the presenting team will be randomly chosen on the day of class.

The grading will be the same as final paper presentation listed above.